Empathy Map

EMPATHY

Understand your user by mapping what they see, hear, say and do — before defining any problem.

SEE

What does she/he see in daily life?

HEAR

What does she/he hear from others?

DO

What does she/he want to do?

THINK

What are her/his concerns?

Persona

EMPATHY

Build a realistic representation of your key user segment to guide design decisions with a human face.

NAME, AGE, LOCATION

Role / Occupation

NEEDS & DESIRES

GOALS & EXPECTATIONS

MOTIVATIONS

INFLUENCES

FRUSTRATIONS

PAIN POINTS

WWWWWH

EMPATHY

Frame your research question from six angles to ensure you observe what truly matters in context.

WHO

Who is involved? Who is affected?

WHAT

What is happening? What is the problem?

WHERE

Where does this happen?

WHEN

When does it occur? How often?

WHY

Why does this happen? Root cause?

HOW

How does it happen? What is the process?

AEIOU

EMPATHY

A structured observation framework: capture Activities, Environments, Interactions, Objects and Users.

ACTIVITIES

What are people doing? Goal-directed actions?

ENVIRONMENTS

What is the character of the space?

INTERACTIONS

What interactions occur between people and objects?

OBJECTS

What objects and devices are present?

USERS

Who is present? What are their roles?

Benchmark

EMPATHY

Compare key features across competitors to identify gaps, opportunities and your unique positioning.

FEATURE	US	*Comp. 1*	*Comp. 2*	*Comp. 3*

Kano Questionnaire

EMPATHY

Ask users to rate each feature both when present and absent to uncover what truly delights or dissatisfies.

FEATURE	Like	Expect	Neutral	Tolerate	Dislike
FUNCTIONAL — IF PRESENT					
	○	○	○	○	○
	○	○	○	○	○
	○	○	○	○	○
	○	○	○	○	○
DYSFUNCTIONAL — IF ABSENT					
	○	○	○	○	○
	○	○	○	○	○
	○	○	○	○	○
	○	○	○	○	○

Kano Interpretation

EMPATHY

Plot functional vs dysfunctional responses to classify features as attractive, must-have, or indifferent.

	Like	Expect	Neutral	Tolerate	Dislike
	I like it				
	I expect it				
	I'm neutral				
	I tolerate it				
	I dislike it				

A: Attractive **M:** Must-have **P:** Performance **I:** Indifferent **R:** Reverse **Q:** Questionable

MoSCoW

EMPATHY

Prioritise requirements by forcing consensus on what must, should, could and will not be delivered.

Total effort allocation

Must + Should = 80% 100% total

MUST HAVE

Non-negotiable requirements

SHOULD HAVE

Important but not vital

COULD HAVE

Nice to have if time allows

WILL NOT HAVE

Explicitly out of scope

Love / Break-up Letter

EMPATHY

Write to a product as if it were a person — to surface emotional highs and frustrations with vivid clarity.

LOVE LETTER

Dear …

Spending time with you is the best part of my day because…

BREAK-UP LETTER

Dear …

I am sorry, I'm leaving you because…

Brainstorming

IDEATION

Generate as many raw ideas as possible in a fixed time. Defer judgement, encourage wild thinking.

TOPIC / CHALLENGE

No judgement — quantity over quality — build on ideas

6-3-5 Brainwriting

IDEATION

Silently generate ideas on paper and pass the sheet — builds on others' thinking without groupthink.

6 participants · 3 ideas each · 5 minutes per round

Round	Idea 1	Idea 2	Idea 3
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Dark Side

IDEATION

Invert each idea to reveal its worst outcome — then flip back to unlock hidden opportunities and risks.

IDEAS

Your original idea

DARK SIDE

Worst possible outcome

Tomorrow's Headlines

IDEATION

Write a future newspaper headline about your solution — forces a bold, user-centred vision of success.

HEADLINE 1

SUMMARY

HEADLINE 2

SUMMARY

HEADLINE 3

SUMMARY

HEADLINE 4

SUMMARY

KJ Technique

IDEATION

Cluster individual observations into affinity groups to reveal patterns, themes and shared meaning.

STEP 1 — WRITE *One observation per sticky*

CLUSTERS **THEME**

Lotus Blossom

IDEATION

Expand a central theme into 8 sub-themes, then use each as the centre of its own blossom.

Place core theme in centre — expand each petal into its own 3×3

Core Theme

Morphological Chart

IDEATION

List key parameters and generate options for each — then combine across rows to create novel solutions.

PARAMETER	*Option 1*	*Option 2*	*Option 3*	*Option 4*	*Option 5*

Harris Profile

EVALUATION

Score alternatives against weighted criteria using a -2 to +2 scale — then compare totals to make an evidence-based decision.

CRITERIA / ALTERNATIVE	-2	-1	+1	+2	-2	-1	+1	+2
	ALTERNATIVE A				ALTERNATIVE B			
TOTAL								

Flowchart

IDEATION

Map process steps, decisions and branches visually — use rectangles for actions, diamonds for yes/no decisions.

Process Decision Start / End YES / NO Branch